

Read the article “A Cowboy Who Rode the Waves.” Then answer the questions.

A Cowboy Who Rode the Waves

by Peggy Reif Miller

Luke Bomberger crossed the Atlantic Ocean 16 times and the Pacific Ocean twice to help people affected by World War II.

1 Luke Bomberger had no idea that his life would change soon after his high school graduation. He was working two part-time jobs in a grocery store and a bank when his friend Don Reist invited him to go to Europe on a cattle boat. Luke couldn't say no. He knew it was an opportunity of a lifetime.

2 It was 1945, World War II was over in Europe, and many countries were left in ruins. To help these countries recover their food supplies, animals, and more, 44 nations joined together to form UNRRA (the United Nations Relief and Rehabilitation Administration). UNRRA hired “Seagoing Cowboys” to take care of the horses, young cows, and mules that were shipped overseas. Luke and Don signed up.

Heading Overseas

3 In August 1945, they received their orders to report to New Orleans. “We arrived August 14,” Luke says, “the day the Pacific war ended.” They got their seaman's papers and boarded the SS *Charles W. Wooster*, headed for Greece—with a cargo of 335 horses plus enough hay and oats to feed them.

4 Luke turned 18 before arriving in Greece, which meant he could be drafted for military service. “When my draft board learned that I was on a cattle-boat trip, they told me to just keep doing that for my service.” By the time he was discharged in 1947, Luke had made nine trips—the most of any Seagoing Cowboy.

5 “The cattle-boat trips were an unbelievable opportunity for a small-town boy,” he says. “Besides helping people, I had the side benefit of seeing Europe and China. But seeing the Acropolis in Greece was special,” he says. “So was taking a gondola ride in Venice, Italy, a city with streets of water.” Luke also toured an excavated castle in Crete and marveled at the Panama Canal on his way to China.

Traveling the High Seas

6 It took about two weeks to cross the Atlantic Ocean from the eastern coast of the United States and a month to get to China. Caring for the animals during the crossings kept Luke busy. They had to be fed and watered two or three times a day. Bales of hay and bags of oats had to be pulled up from the lower holds of the ship. Stalls had to be cleaned.

7 Helping out on his aunt Katie's farm as a boy had prepared Luke for hard work, but not for the dangers at sea. On his second trip, Luke served as night watchman. His job was to check on all the animals every hour. One rainy night, after making his hourly report to the captain, he slid down a slippery ladder on his backside. Luke's heart raced as he shot feet first toward an opening on the side of the ship. A small strip of metal along the edge stopped his slide, keeping him from flying overboard into the dark Atlantic. He was happy to be alive. But he couldn't work for a couple of days because of cracked ribs.

8 Luke also found time to have fun on board, especially on return trips after the animals had been unloaded. The cowboys played baseball and volleyball games in the empty holds where animals had been housed. Table-tennis tournaments, fencing, boxing, reading, whittling, and games also helped pass the time.

9 But being a Seagoing Cowboy was much more than an adventure for Luke Bomberger. It opened up the world to him. “I'm grateful for the opportunity,” he says. “It made me more aware of people of other countries and their needs.” And that awareness stayed with him, leading his family to host a number of international students and exchange visitors for many years.

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Prewriting/Planning

Use the blank Prewriting/Planning space below for notes, lists, webs, outlines, or anything else that might help you plan your writing. If you need additional space for planning, raise your hand and your teacher will give you a sheet of scratch paper. **You must write your final draft in the box on the right.**

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Now check your writing using this Editing Checklist.

Editing Checklist

- 1 Check your capitalization and punctuation.
- 2 Spell all words correctly.
- 3 Check for sentence fragments or run-on sentences.
- 4 Keep verb tense consistent.
- 5 Use words according to the rules of Standard English.
- 6 Remember to paragraph correctly.

You have just read the article, “A Cowboy Who Rode the Waves.” Luke's participation in the Seagoing Cowboys program allowed him to experience adventures and visit many unique places. Using information from the article, write an argument from Luke's point of view convincing others to participate in the Seagoing Cowboys program.

Be sure to include

- reasons to join the program
- details from the article to support Luke's claims
- an introduction, a body, and a conclusion to your essay

Final Draft

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